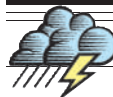


The Washington Post

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Work at some labs, offices at a standstill

EPA, NOAA programs among those frozen by DOGE spending limits

BY HANNAH NATANSON AND MAXINE JOSELOW

At the Environmental Protection Agency, research at 11 laboratories has ground to a halt because the Trump administration has not approved most new lab purchases.

At the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, key work on weather forecasting has slowed to a crawl because Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick must sign off personally on many contracts and grants. And at the Social Security Administration, some employees are running out of paper, pens and printer toner because the U.S. DOGE Service has placed a \$1 spending limit on government-issued credit cards. (DOGE stands for Department of Government Efficiency, though it is not a Cabinet-level agency.)

Across the federal government, Trump officials are halting a wide range of operations by declining to approve key funds. This unofficial hold on many activities has incapacitated many agencies' divisions, even though they remain technically intact.

This account of how the administration and DOGE are stalling government operations is based on interviews with more than a dozen federal employees across eight agencies, as well as several internal emails and documents reviewed by The Washington Post. The employees spoke on the condition of anonymity for fear of retribution.

The effects are especially pronounced at the EPA, where staffers at 11 labs have struggled to continue researching an array of environmental threats, including air and water pollution as well as

SEE GOVERNMENT ON A5



ALLISON JOYCE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Months after Helene, it's slow going in parts of N.C.

BURNSVILLE, N.C. — The day of Bobby Hensley's stroke in February, Green Leaf Road was so muddy and pockmarked that an ambulance couldn't make it to the 82-year-old Air Force veteran's house.

The steep dirt road in Yancey County, North Carolina, has always been in rough condition. But since the tropical storm remnants of Hurricane Helene blew through seven months ago, the privately owned road has been disfigured by deep craters, making it often impassable for many vehicles.

Green Leaf is just one of the approximately 8,000 private

Thousands of private roads and bridges in the state are still in need of repairs

BY ALLISON JOYCE AND RUBY MELLEN

Eugene Hensley works on repairs to Green Leaf Road in Burnsville, North Carolina, in March. The private road was heavily damaged by a tropical storm last year.

roads and bridges in this state that were decimated by Helene last fall, according to the office of North Carolina Gov. Josh Stein (D). More than 7,000 still need to be fixed, according to Natasha Rodriguez, the operations director of Operation Helo, a nonprofit organization that allocates donations to repairs.

The biggest disaster recovery in North Carolina's history has, in some ways, moved along: The state has repaired highways, small businesses are reopening and tourists are returning to hot spots like Asheville. But rebuilding has been slower in many rural

SEE NORTH CAROLINA ON A6

Trump's Mideast focus is business

4-DAY TRIP AIMS TO CEMENT TRADE TIES

Private ventures blurred with foreign policy goals

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM AND MATT VISER

President Donald Trump plans to leave Monday for a four-day trip to Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the United Arab Emirates, a mission that is expected to focus heavily on business deals and new investments from the oil-rich region.

The swing through deep-pocketed Middle Eastern monarchies, Trump's first major international travel of his second term, is a marker of the president's priorities and another sign of his intention to de-emphasize the traditional U.S. allies that typically serve as the first foreign destinations for new presidents. It also reflects his affection for the region, its wealth and the pageantry that the host countries plan to roll out for him.

The visit comes amid a sweep of pressing regional security concerns, including the fate of Gaza, Iran's nuclear program and Trump's long-held goal of brokering a deal that would normalize relations between Saudi Arabia and Israel. The Gaza war has thrown the region into tumult, leaving Iran and its proxies at their weakest in recent memory and creating an unusual moment in which power balances could shift.

White House aides said the security issues would not be central during the 3½ days Trump will be on the ground, a testament to the president's more restrained vision for the role of the United

SEE MIDDLE EAST ON A4

Hostage: Hamas says it will release U.S. citizen Edan Alexander. **A13**

L.A. port is among first casualties of trade war

Empty berths, idle cranes show effects of sky-high tariffs on Chinese goods

BY DAVID J. LYNCH

LOS ANGELES — On a sunny spring morning, when the Port of Los Angeles should be a blur of activity, more than half of the container ship berths here sit empty. The steel booms on dozens of towering ship-to-shore cranes point idly to the sky.

These are the front lines of President Donald Trump's trade war.

The number of shipping containers that arrived at the nation's top container port last week was roughly one-third lower than during the same period last year — a sharper decline than during the depths of the Great Recession.

SEE PORT ON A2

Trade talks: The White House says a deal was reached with China. **A3**



IVAN PIERRE AGUIRRE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Judicial candidate Silvia Delgado passes out fliers at a market in Ciudad Juárez, Mexico.

Narco ties shadow Mexico judicial election

BY MARY BETH SHERIDAN

CIUDAD JUÁREZ, MEXICO — When the Mexican government announced it was holding the world's largest judicial election — with voters electing thousands of magistrates and an entirely new Supreme Court — it hoped to bring fresh faces into the legal system.

Civic leaders. Idealistic young attorneys. What it didn't expect was El Chapo's lawyer.

Yet here is Silvia Delgado, 51, in a snug black minidress and four-inch heels, handing out

leaflets and smiling brightly at vendors at a Sunday flea market. Eight years ago, she was counsel to Joaquín “El Chapo” Guzmán when he was extradited from this city's fortresslike prison to New York. She accompanied his beauty queen wife, Emma Coronel, during the U.S. trial that ended with his life sentence. Now Delgado hopes to be a criminal-court judge, in a state where El Chapo's Sinaloa cartel remains powerful. “I hope I can count on your vote!” she calls to bargain-hunters.

SEE MEXICO ON A12

Confusion grows from measles ‘doublespeak’

Kennedy is promoting vaccines while placating their hard-line skeptics

BY LAUREN WEBER

Early last month, after two Texas children had died of measles, Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. acknowledged that the MMR vaccine prevents the spread of that virus. But later that day, he posted photos of himself with anti-vaccine doctors, calling them “extraordinary healers” and promoting unproven treatments.

In a television interview three days later, Kennedy, the nation's top health official, encouraged vaccination for measles. In the same conversation, he cast doubt on whether one of the children had actually died of measles-related complications.

And in an interview with Phil McGraw at the end of April, Kennedy said of the measles vaccine: “HHS continues to recommend that vaccine. But there are problems with the vaccine.”

With the nation in the grip of the deadliest measles outbreak

in decades, Kennedy is equivocating with a worried U.S. public, health experts said. His mixed message appeals to vaccine believers and skeptics, muddying public health instructions at a time when clarity is essential.

Elevated from longtime anti-vaccine activist to guardian of the nation's health, Kennedy is trying to appeal to both sides: the public, which largely supports vaccination, and the anti-vaccine hard-liners who helped propel his rise. His “double-speak,” as public health experts and academics who follow the anti-vaccine movement call it, gives him cover with both groups, allowing him to court public opinion while still assuaging his anti-vaccine base.

At least half of adults are uncertain whether to believe false claims about measles, its vaccine and its treatment, according to an April poll by the health-care think tank KFF.

“It's confusing, and maybe that's part of the strategy,” said Bruce Gellin, who oversaw HHS's vaccine program in the Bush and Obama administrations. Gellin noted that confusion could lead parents to opt out of vaccination — exactly what health officials do not want in an outbreak.

SEE RFK JR. ON A8

IN THE NEWS

Pope Leo XIV Delivering a Sunday blessing, the new pontiff echoed his predecessor but continued to emerge as his own man. **A13**

Ukraine negotiations President Donald Trump backed Russian President Vladimir Putin's call for direct talks with Kyiv, breaking an agreement with European allies. **A13**

THE NATION **Qatar is discussing** the donation of an aircraft for use by Trump. **A4** **A Trump aide** has suggested suspending habeas corpus, the right of a person to challenge their detention in court. **A7**

THE WORLD **Britain is still** trying to make sense of a landmark court ruling on transgender people. **A10** **Many Indian students** attending college in the U.S. are rethinking their plans under Trump. **A11**

THE ECONOMY **Tariffs have sent** the prices of fast-fashion retailer Shein's clothing soaring, per a Washington Post analysis. **A16**

THE REGION **Households** across the D.C. area are feeling the pinch from U.S. DOGE Service-led cuts, a Post poll finds. **B1**

D.C. Bar elections have seen a dramatic rise in voting this cycle, which has been animated by candidates with ties to Trump appointees. **B1** **A former mayor** of University Park was ordered held until trial on child pornography charges. **B1**

STYLE **Melania Trump** has been less visible in Washington in her second term as first lady, but her agenda this go-round appears to be taking shape. **C1** **A roundup** of the major players in the sex-trafficking trial of Sean “Diddy” Combs. **C1**

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